

ADRIANO MONTEIRO

NUTRITION COACH

Environment Design

How to build a space where the right choice is the easy one

COMPLETE GUIDE 3 OF 5

adrianonutrition.com

Contents

Start here

It is not you, it is the setup

Friction: make it easy or hard

Kitchen architecture

Bedroom and training space

Your digital environment

Your social environment

Commitment devices and if-then plans

The full reset

Environment design for ADHD

When you cannot control the space

The 30-day environment audit

Pick your case: starter plans

Worksheets

Disclaimer. This educational resource presents behavioral and environmental strategies for personal development. It does not constitute medical, psychological, psychiatric or therapeutic advice. The author is a nutrition coach, not a licensed healthcare provider. If you have a mental health condition, an eating disorder, a substance dependence or any other clinical concern, consult a qualified professional before making changes. Stopping alcohol after heavy use can be dangerous and should be done with medical guidance. Individual results vary.

BEFORE YOU READ

Start here

You have probably tried to change a habit by trying harder. This guide is about changing the **place** instead. Your home, your phone, your calendar and the people around you send you cues all day. If those cues point at the wrong behavior, you can fight them with willpower, or you can rearrange them once and let them work for you.

Environment design is not a magic trick, and I will not pretend it is. The research is real but often smaller and messier than the internet claims, so I tell you how strong each idea is. Where I could not verify a popular statistic, I left it out.

How to use this guide

- **Start with ONE room and ONE behavior.** Not the whole house. Chapter 11 has a seven-day start.
- **Change the space before you try to change yourself.** Move first, motivate later.
- **Use it with Guide 1.** TRANSFORM step R (Redesign) is the short version. This guide is the full one.
- **If you have ADHD,** read Chapter 9. Out of sight really does mean out of mind, and you can use that on purpose.

CHAPTER 1

It is not you, it is the setup

We blame character and ignore the situation

Psychologists have long documented that people explain behavior by character and underestimate the role of the situation. Lee Ross called it the **fundamental attribution error.**[1] When you skip the gym you think "I am lazy." You rarely think "my gym bag was in the trunk of a car I did not take, the route had traffic, and I had no plan for when I was tired." Seeing the situation is the first step to changing it.

The willpower tank is a weak foundation

A popular explanation says self-control is a tank that empties with use. That idea, called ego depletion, was one of the most famous findings in psychology. It has not held up. A 23-laboratory preregistered replication with 2,141 participants found an effect of d = 0.04, which is statistically indistinguishable from zero,[2] and a later project with 36 laboratories found d = 0.06.[3] Researchers still debate why, but you should not build your life on a tank that may not exist.

What this means for you

If the willpower story is shaky, then the useful question is not "How do I get more discipline?" It is "What does my environment make easy, and is that what I want?"

Habits are tied to place

A habit is a behavior cued by context, so changing the context changes the habit. In a study of students transferring to a new university, their exercise, newspaper reading and TV watching habits **survived the move only when the context stayed similar** (for example, reading the paper with the same people). When the context changed, the habits broke down and behavior followed current intentions again.[4] Reviews by Wendy Wood and colleagues reach the same conclusion: habits are triggered by cues, and altering the cues is one of the most reliable levers we have.[5]

CHAPTER 2

Friction: make it easy or hard

Friction is the effort between you and an action. High friction makes an action less likely. Low friction makes it more likely. Apps are built to remove friction (one-tap buying, autoplay). You can do the same in reverse.

What the evidence says

A Cochrane systematic review of 24 randomized trials looked at changing how **available** or how **close** food is. Having fewer options available lowered selection of the targeted food, and placing food farther away reduced how much people ate (SMD -0.60 across 15 comparisons, 1,098 people). The authors rated the certainty as **low or very low**, and the studies were mostly small laboratory experiments with snack foods.[6] So the direction is consistent, and the exact size is uncertain.

About some viral numbers

You may have seen statistics like "candy in a clear bowl gets eaten 66% more" or "food at eye level is eaten twice as much." Many of these come from a Cornell food lab, and several of that lab's papers were later retracted or corrected. I do not use those numbers. The trend (closer and more visible means more eaten) is supported by the independent trials above, but not the precise figures.

The friction ladder

To do LESS of something	To do MORE of something
Remove it (do not buy it, delete the app)	**Pre-load it** (clothes laid out, bag packed, food prepped)
Put it far away (top shelf, basement, other room)	**Put it close** (counter, desk, front door)
Make it a hassle (opaque container, log out, remove saved card)	**Make it visible** (clear container, book on the pillow)
Make it slower (wait 10 minutes, ask a friend first)	**Make it automatic** (alarm, default, recurring order)

Use the strongest step you can live with. If you can stop buying the thing, that beats hiding it. If you cannot, move it up the ladder one step.

The seconds test

Count the seconds between you and each behavior. Your aim: the behavior you want is a few seconds away and the one you do not want is at least a minute away. This is my practical rule of thumb from coaching, not a laboratory threshold. It is useful because it turns a vague idea into something you can measure and fix.

CHAPTER 3

Kitchen architecture

The kitchen is the highest-leverage room for most nutrition goals, because it is where decisions about food actually get made, usually when you are hungry and tired.

Arrange by how often you want to reach for it

Zone	Put here
Eye level and the front of the fridge	Washed, cut vegetables and fruit in clear containers. Ready protein: boiled eggs, Greek yogurt, cooked chicken, hummus.
Counter	Fruit bowl. Water bottle. Your supplements, if you use any, next to where you eat breakfast.
Waist level	Rice, oats, beans, canned fish, nuts in a portion-sized container.
High shelves, back of the pantry	Anything you are trying to eat less of. Snacks, sweets, alcohol, if you keep them at all.

Portion and tableware size

A Cochrane review of 72 studies found a small to moderate effect: people **consistently eat more when they are served larger portions, packages or tableware.** The estimate was that a sustained reduction in exposure to large sizes across a whole diet could cut about 144 to 228 kcal per day, with moderate-quality evidence for portions and weaker evidence for plate size specifically.[7] So smaller portions help. Do not expect a smaller plate alone to transform your results.

Shop the environment, not the willpower

- **Shop with a list and after a meal.** Never when hungry.
- **Do not buy your trigger foods.** The best moment to resist is in the store, once, not at 9 PM ten times.
- **Buy single servings** of the foods you overeat, if you buy them at all.
- **Keep a default meal at home.** Eggs, rice, frozen vegetables. When life is messy you are never starting from zero.

Kitchen audit (15 minutes)

Open the fridge and the pantry. Write down what you see first. Move one healthy thing to eye level and one trigger food out of sight. Photograph it. Look again in a week.

CHAPTER 4

Bedroom and training space

The bedroom is for sleep

In a small crossover study, 12 adults read for several evenings on a light-emitting e-reader and on a printed book. With the e-reader they took longer to fall asleep, had less evening sleepiness, **suppressed melatonin and shifted their body clock later,** and were less alert the next morning.[8] A survey of 844 adults found that using a phone in bed after lights out predicted worse sleep and more daytime fatigue.[9] These are small or observational studies, but the practical advice is simple and low cost.

- **Phone charges outside the bedroom.** Use a cheap alarm clock.
- **Screens off about an hour before bed,** or at least dim and use night mode.
- **Cool, dark and quiet.** The thermal environment affects sleep, and most people sleep better in a cooler room than they think.[10] Individual comfort varies, so pick what works for you.
- **The nightstand test:** what is within reach decides what you do. Phone means scrolling, book means reading, nothing means sleeping.

Guide 5 covers sleep in depth. This is the environment part of it.

The training space

- **Gym clothes the night before,** bag by the door.
- **Equipment in plain sight.** A kettlebell in the closet is a decoration. A kettlebell by the sofa gets used.
- **Choose the gym on your normal route.** I could not find a reliable study that gives an exact distance, so I will not quote one. The principle is clear: the fewer extra steps between you and the session, the more often it happens.
- **Book the class,** and tell someone. See Chapter 7.

CHAPTER 5

Your digital environment

Your phone is the environment you carry into every other room. Treat it like a room.

Notifications

Every notification is a cue. In a randomized study of 221 people, a week with notifications **turned on led to more inattention and more hyperactivity symptoms** than a week with them turned off, and turning them off did not significantly change productivity.[11] That finding is especially relevant if you have ADHD. It is a short study with self-reported measures, so treat it as a strong hint, not a guarantee, and test it yourself.

Social media

In a randomized experiment, 143 students limited Facebook, Instagram and Snapchat to **10 minutes per platform per day** for three weeks. Compared with the control group, they reported **significantly less loneliness and depression** by the end.[12] It is one study in students, but it shows that the limit, not total abstinence, can be enough.

A practical digital reset

1. **Turn off every notification** except calls and the few people who truly need you.
2. **Delete social apps from your phone** and use the browser. The extra login is friction. (Muting is not.)
3. **Move apps off the home screen.** First screen: tools you want to use (notes, camera, maps, a book).
4. **Charge the phone away from your bed and your desk.**
5. **Schedule email.** Three fixed times a day instead of constantly.
6. **Try grayscale for a week.** I have seen it make a phone less tempting, but I cannot point to strong trials, so treat it as an experiment.

Today

Open your phone settings and turn off notifications for every app that is not a person. It takes five minutes.

CHAPTER 6

Your social environment

The evidence, and its limits

A famous analysis of the Framingham Heart Study followed 12,067 people from 1971 to 2003. It found that a person's chance of becoming obese rose by **57%** if a friend became obese.[13] The study was observational, and other economists showed that, using different statistical methods, the "contagion" effect could not be separated from shared environment.[14] So treat it as a reason to **notice your circle,** not as proof that friends make you gain weight.

A clearer message comes from trials. In a randomized trial of 166 people, those recruited **with friends** and given social support strategies did better: **95% completed treatment and 66% fully maintained their weight loss** at 10 months, compared with 76% and 24% among those who came alone and had standard treatment.[15] Support works. Doing it with someone changes the odds.

Audit your five

Person	Time per week	Supports / neutral / undermines	What I will do

You are not looking for people to cut off. You are looking for **where to add more** of the people who help, and where to set a boundary with the ones who do not. If your goal is sobriety, this matters even more.

Scripts that protect your plan

- "I am not drinking tonight, but I would love to hang out."
- "No thanks, I am good. What is everyone ordering?"
- "I am working on something and it helps if I do not have it around. Can we keep it out of the shared space?"
- "Can I count on you to ask me about it on Friday?"

Join **one** group built around the identity you want: a gym or a CrossFit box, a running club, a support group. A review of mutual-help programs such as Alcoholics Anonymous found they are often as effective as, or better than, other treatments for staying abstinent, and they tend to cost much less.[16] The common ingredient is a community.

CHAPTER 7

Commitment devices and if-then plans

Odysseus asked his crew to tie him to the mast so he could hear the Sirens without steering toward them. A **commitment device** does the same: a choice made now that limits a weaker future moment.

What research supports

- **Deadlines you set yourself.** In experiments with students, those who were allowed to set their own deadlines did better than those with a single deadline at the end, though not as well as those given evenly spaced deadlines by someone else.[17]
- **Money on the line.** In a field trial in the Philippines, people who put their own money into a savings account that they would lose if they failed a nicotine test were more likely to pass a test at 6 months.[18]
- **Social stakes.** Book a class with a friend. Skipping means texting them, not just yourself. This is my coaching version of the above.

If-then plans

A meta-analysis of 94 tests found that forming "if [situation], then I will [action]" plans had a medium-to-large effect on goal attainment (d = 0.65).[19] The format pre-wires the cue and the response so you do not have to decide in the moment. Write one for the situation that most often breaks your plan.

If...	Then I will...
I feel like grabbing my phone in bed	Put it in the other room and read two pages
I get home hungry and tired	Eat the default meal that is already prepped
Someone offers me a drink	Say my line and order a sparkling water

I do not feel like training	Put on my shoes and do 10 minutes. If I still hate it, I stop.
It is 3 PM and I want a snack	Drink water, wait 10 minutes, then decide

CHAPTER 8

The full reset

Sometimes a space is so full of old cues that small edits drift back. When your context changes a lot (a move, a breakup, a new job), habits are more likely to be disrupted and behavior is easier to redirect. Researchers call this the **habit discontinuity** idea: moments of big change are windows for starting new patterns.[4][20] You can create a small version of that window on purpose.

The weekend reset

1. **Pick one room** (the kitchen, the bedroom, the desk). Not the whole house.
2. **Empty it,** or at least clear the surfaces. Remove every cue for the old behavior.
3. **Clean it.** A clean space signals a new start.
4. **Rebuild it for the person you are becoming.** Put back only what supports the new behavior, in the places you will see it.
5. **Do the new routine once that evening.** Make dinner, make the bed, charge the phone in the new spot. First repetition counts.

Do not do this for every habit. Use it when you have tried small changes in the same space more than once and it keeps sliding back.

CHAPTER 9

Environment design for ADHD

With ADHD, what is out of sight is often out of mind. That is a problem when your good habits are hidden, and a tool when your bad habits are. The principles below come from my own practice and my coaching, not from trials, so test them.

1. **Make good cues loud and bad cues invisible.** Put the water bottle on the keyboard. Put the chips in a cupboard you do not open.

2. **Create a landing strip.** One spot by the door for keys, wallet, bag, gym clothes and the thing you must not forget tomorrow. If it is not on the strip, it does not exist.
3. **Use physical timers and alarms,** not only your phone. A kitchen timer does not come with notifications.
4. **Use a wall calendar or whiteboard** where you walk past it every day.
5. **One purpose per place.** The desk is for work, the bed for sleep. If you work on the couch and scroll at the desk, your brain gets mixed signals.
6. **Try body doubling:** work next to someone, in person or online. It is popular in the ADHD community and many people find it helpful, but formal research is still limited.
7. **Reduce choice.** The fewer things on the surface, the fewer things to distract you.

Be kind to your future self

If your space gets messy again, that is not failure, it is data. Ask what made it hard to keep and adjust the system. Do not blame yourself.

CHAPTER 10

When you cannot control the space

If...	Try this
I share my home with people who will not change	Control your own zone: your shelf in the fridge, your desk, your nightstand. Ask, do not demand: "Can the cookies live in a cupboard and the fruit on the counter?" Partial changes still help.
I need my phone for work	Keep the tools, delete the feeds. Use scheduled windows for what you cannot remove.
I live in a small space	One shelf, one drawer, one hook by the door. The principle scales down.
I travel a lot	Pack the same small kit: bands, shoes, protein, a water bottle. Choose the hotel by the breakfast and the gym. Plan the first meal at the destination.
I am in a very stressful season	Do only one thing: phone out of the bedroom. That alone helps your sleep.

CHAPTER 11

The 30-day environment audit

Week	Goal	What to do
1	**Observe**	Track every time the behavior happens, with the cue: what you saw, where, who, how you felt.
2	**Remove**	Eliminate the most obvious cues. Where you cannot, add friction.
3	**Replace**	Add visible cues for the new behavior and take friction out of it.
4	**Refine**	Look at what changed. Keep what works. Fix one thing that did not.

Your first seven days

Redesigning everything is overwhelming. One room is not.

Day	Task
1	Pick ONE behavior to change and name the room where it most often happens.
2	Audit that room: what is at eye level, within reach, visible from the doorway?
3	Remove or hide cues for the behavior you do not want. Do not add anything yet.
4	Add ONE visible cue for the behavior you do want, where the old cue used to be.
5	Do the same for your phone: notifications, home screen.
6	Write one if-then plan for your hardest situation.
7	Review without judgment. Pick the next room.

CHAPTER 12

Pick your case: starter plans

If this is you...	Your starter plan

I snack at night	Remove the snack from the house or move it to a high, opaque spot. Put a ready alternative at eye level. If-then for 9 PM. Kitchen closes after dinner (brush teeth early).
I scroll for hours	Notifications off. Delete social apps, use browser. Phone charges outside the bedroom.
I skip workouts	Clothes and bag ready the night before. Book with a friend. Put the gear where you will see it.
I want to stop drinking	Talk to a doctor first if you drink heavily. Remove alcohol from the home. Tell one person. Join a group. Scripts from Chapter 6.
I sleep badly	Phone out. Cool, dark room. Screens off an hour before bed. Then read Guide 5.
I have ADHD and feel scattered	Landing strip, wall calendar, physical timers, one purpose per place. Chapter 9.

APPENDIX

Worksheets

1. Room audit

Question	Your answer
Behavior I want to change	
Room where it happens	
What I see first when I walk in	
Cues I will remove or hide	
Cue I will add (and where)	
Seconds between me and the wanted behavior	
Seconds between me and the unwanted behavior	

2. Digital audit

Item	Done
Notifications off except calls and key people	[ ]
Social apps deleted from phone	[ ]
Home screen has only tools I want	[ ]
Phone charges outside the bedroom	[ ]
Email checked at fixed times	[ ]

3. My if-then plans

If...	Then I will...

About the author

Adriano Monteiro is a nutrition coach with Precision Nutrition certifications. He has lost 38 kg of fat, has competed in CrossFit for 8 years, has been sober for 4 years and has been in treatment for ADHD for 2 years. He writes and coaches for people who want lasting change without having to suffer in silence, and works with clients in English from Brazil.

Want help redesigning YOUR space?

Book a free 20-minute call. We will walk through your home, your phone and your week and pick the first three changes. No pressure, no sales pitch, just a plan.

Book your free 20-minute call

https://calendly.com/adriano-nutrition/free-20-min-discovery-call

References

1. Ross, L. (1977). The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process. *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, 10, 173-220.
2. Hagger, M. S., et al. (2016). A multilab preregistered replication of the ego-depletion effect. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 11(4), 546-573.
3. Vohs, K. D., et al. (2021). A multisite preregistered paradigmatic test of the ego-depletion effect. *Psychological Science*, 32(10), 1566-1581.
4. Wood, W., Tam, L., & Witt, M. G. (2005). Changing circumstances, disrupting habits. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 88(6), 918-933.
5. Wood, W., & Neal, D. T. (2016). Healthy through habit: Interventions for initiating and maintaining health behavior change. *Behavioral Science & Policy*, 2(1), 71-83.
6. Hollands, G. J., et al. (2019). Altering the availability or proximity of food, alcohol, and tobacco products to change their selection and consumption. *Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews*, 9, CD012573.
7. Hollands, G. J., et al. (2015). Portion, package or tableware size for changing selection and consumption of food, alcohol and tobacco. *Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews*, 9, CD011045.
8. Chang, A. M., Aeschbach, D., Duffy, J. F., & Czeisler, C. A. (2015). Evening use of light-emitting eReaders negatively affects sleep, circadian timing, and next-morning alertness. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(4), 1232-1237.
9. Exelmans, L., & Van den Bulck, J. (2016). Bedtime mobile phone use and sleep in adults. *Social Science & Medicine*, 148, 93-101.
10. Okamoto-Mizuno, K., & Mizuno, K. (2012). Effects of thermal environment on sleep and circadian rhythm. *Journal of Physiological Anthropology*, 31, 14.
11. Kushlev, K., Proulx, J., & Dunn, E. W. (2016). "Silence your phones": Smartphone notifications increase inattention and hyperactivity symptoms. *Proceedings of the 2016 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 1011-1020.
12. Hunt, M. G., Marx, R., Lipson, C., & Young, J. (2018). No more FOMO: Limiting social media decreases loneliness and depression. *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 37(10), 751-768.
13. Christakis, N. A., & Fowler, J. H. (2007). The spread of obesity in a large social network over 32 years. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 357(4), 370-379.
14. Cohen-Cole, E., & Fletcher, J. M. (2008). Is obesity contagious? Social networks vs. environmental factors in the obesity epidemic. *Journal of Health Economics*, 27(5), 1382-1387.
15. Wing, R. R., & Jeffery, R. W. (1999). Benefits of recruiting participants with friends and increasing social support for weight loss and maintenance. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology*, 67(1), 132-138.
16. Kelly, J. F., Humphreys, K., & Ferri, M. (2020). Alcoholics Anonymous and other 12-step programs for alcohol use disorder. *Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews*, 3, CD012880.
17. Ariely, D., & Wertenbroch, K. (2002). Procrastination, deadlines, and performance: Self-control by precommitment. *Psychological Science*, 13(3), 219-224.
18. Gine, X., Karlan, D., & Zinman, J. (2010). Put your money where your butt is: A commitment contract for smoking cessation. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 2(4), 213-235.
19. Gollwitzer, P. M., & Sheeran, P. (2006). Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes. *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, 38, 69-119.
20. Verplanken, B., & Wood, W. (2006). Interventions to break and create consumer habits. *Journal of Public Policy & Marketing*, 25(1), 90-103.